The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: TASNIM NEWS/AFP via Getty Images

Donald Trump said America sunk Iranian boats in the **Strait of Hormuz**. He accused **Iran** of hitting "unrelated nations" after **South Korea** reported explosions on a commercial ship. Mr Trump said America would "guide" the ships of neutral countries through the waterway. Iran threatened to attack "foreign armed forces" that enter and disputed claims that two American vessels had crossed. Meanwhile the UAE reported a fire at an oil facility following an Iranian drone attack.

India's ruling **Bharatiya Janata Party** took control of the state of **West Bengal**, an opposition stronghold, following the country's state elections. It marks a significant breakthrough for Prime Minister Narendra Modi's party, which has never governed West Bengal. More than 68m people voted in the election, a record turnout.

Sir Keir Starmer acknowledged heightened "tension" with America over the war in Iran and said it was in Britain's "national interest" to be closer to **Europe**, while attending the European Political Community summit in Armenia. More than 40 European leaders, including Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, met in

Armenia's capital on Monday, where Britain began discussions to join the EU's loan scheme for Ukraine.

Anthropic partnered with private-equity firms to launch a new company that will sell its AI tools to businesses. The joint venture, which includes Blackstone, Goldman Sachs and Hellman & Friedman, is estimated to be worth $1.5bn and will teach other companies how to integrate Anthropic's technology. OpenAI is also courting similar deals with Wall Street.

At least two people were killed and three more were seriously injured after a car drove into a crowd in **Leipzig**, a German city. A suspect has been arrested. Burkhard Jung, the city's mayor, said there was "no longer any danger" and that a motive was not yet known. Several people have been killed in vehicle-ramming incidents in Germany in recent years.

A suspected **Ukrainian** drone hit a luxury residential skyscraper in Moscow, causing damage but no casualties. **Russia** said it has intercepted a wave of drone attacks in recent days. The latest strike comes days before Moscow hosts its annual Victory Day military parade; last week the Kremlin said the pageant would be scaled back, citing "the terrorist threat" from Ukraine.

Three **cruise ship** passengers died after a suspected outbreak of **hantavirus**, a rare infection primarily found in rodents. The *MV Hondius* left Argentina around three weeks ago, making several stops as it crossed the Atlantic. The Dutch-flagged ship, now anchored off the coast of Cape Verde, will be blocked from docking, the island's public health officials said.

Figure of the day: 130%, the amount by which eBay's share price has jumped since 2024. Read about the online marketplace's remarkable comeback.

Photograph: Shutterstock

Rising antisemitism in Britain

A series of violent antisemitic attacks has increased anxiety among British Jews to “another level”, Sir Keir Starmer, the prime minister, said over the weekend. On Wednesday two Jewish men were stabbed in Golders Green, a neighbourhood in the London borough that has the highest density of Britain’s roughly 300,000 Jews. Essa Suleiman, a 45-year-old man, has been charged with attempted murder. In recent months synagogues and vehicles belonging to a Jewish charity have been attacked too.

Sir Keir has pledged extra police funding and faster sentencing, but Jewish leaders worry antisemitism is being normalised as attitudes towards Israel sour. The thorniest question is how to curb hatred flowing through social media and anti-Israel protest marches without trampling free speech. A government review of public-order legislation, commissioned after a deadly attack on a synagogue in Manchester in October, is already months late. But Britain’s government will struggle to solve the root problem: legal measures rarely alter attitudes.

Photograph: AP

What next for German-American ties?

Last year Friedrich Merz reckoned negotiating with Donald Trump would be “very easy”. Not anymore. Last week Germany’s chancellor said that America “obviously has no strategy” for its war with Iran. Mr Trump retaliated swiftly on social media and in real life. On Friday the Pentagon announced plans to withdraw 5,000 of America’s 39,000 troops at German bases. Mr Trump claimed more would follow.

It could be merely bluster. A similar decision in Mr Trump’s first term was cancelled after being slow-rolled by Congress. What really worries German officials is America scrapping a deal made in 2024 to station American intermediate-range missiles in Germany. This agreement buys Europe time to build up its own deterrence after Russia installed nuclear-capable missiles in Kaliningrad, its exclave on the Baltic coast.

The spat broke out while Mr Merz’s position is more precarious than ever: his approval rating and coalition support are both disintegrating. With eastern state elections in September, Mr Merz may wish to revise his own strategy.

Photograph: AP

The BJP looks set to finally conquer West Bengal

Results have begun rolling in for elections in four Indian states. Early counting suggests that two of them—Assam and West Bengal in the country's east—have been swept by the Bharatiya Janata Party. India's ruling party, however, struggled in the south. In Kerala a coalition led by Congress, the national opposition, is expected to topple the ruling communists. In Tamil Nadu a new party formed by Vijay, a film star, looks set to break a decades-long duopoly of regional parties.

For the BJP, any disappointment in the south looks set to be far outweighed by the joy of winning West Bengal. The Hindu-nationalist party had long struggled to make inroads there; Mamata Banerjee of the All India Trinamool Congress party has led the state for 15 years. Yet as the BJP celebrates what looks like a landmark win, questions swirl over the election process. The vote was preceded by a controversial revision of voter rolls that disqualified more than 9m voters (roughly 12% of the electorate). Opposition leaders alleged wrongdoing. Following the BJP's apparent landslide victory, expect those complaints to get louder.

Photograph: Getty Images

Nigeria’s rocky economic recovery

For a while, Nigeria’s economy had been on an upward trajectory. Painful reforms, including floating the currency and scrapping fuel subsidies, had slowly stabilised the economy since 2023. GDP and foreign reserves had risen; inflation was down.

But in December the finance minister, Wale Edun, punctured the optimism by announcing that the government was set to miss its 2025 revenue target by approximately 30trn naira ($20bn) and had already borrowed heavily to fill fiscal gaps. During his tenure Mr Edun repeatedly attempted to reduce the government’s increasingly expensive debt burden (which gobbles up some 60% of revenues). In April, a cabinet reshuffle saw Mr Edun abruptly depart his post.

These woes have been worsened by rising fuel costs and higher inflation as a result of turmoil in the Gulf. Nigeria’s economy is still growing: a monthly survey of business conditions published on Monday by Stanbic IBTC Bank—a useful proxy for growth—pointed to a third consecutive month of private-sector expansion in April. But its foundations remain fragile.

Photograph: Shutterstock

The Met Gala, sponsored by Jeff Bezos

On Monday New York's richest and most famous will descend (very, very slowly) down the steps of the Metropolitan Museum of Art. The Met Gala, fashion's glitziest night, has run for almost 80 years, raising both funds for the museum's costume institute—a record $31m last year—and web traffic, as fashionistas pore over their outrageous couture.

Since 1995 Anna Wintour, *Vogue* magazine's grande dame, has handpicked the event's attendees and its enigmatic theme. (Designers will no doubt find this year's "fashion is art" far easier than the 2004 directive to draw on "furniture in the 18th century".) No matter how obscure the attire is, the gala cannot escape politics. This year's lead sponsors are Jeff Bezos, Amazon's founder, and his wife Lauren Sánchez Bezos, leading protesters to call for boycotts over the billionaire's chuminess with Donald Trump. Zohran Mamdani, New York's leftist mayor, is breaking with precedent and skipping the event. Mr Bezos is unlikely to mind.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which prog rock group was founded by Syd Barrett, Nick Mason, Roger Waters and Richard Wright?

Habit is a cable; we weave a thread of it each day, and at last we cannot break it.

Horace Mann